

Multifunctional Devices

Why MFDs?

A typical office has a fax machine, copier, printer and scanner, all in different locations—often the first available space. Your daily exercise routine probably involves scanning a picture, going back to your PC to print it, picking up the printout, marching to the fax machine to send it off to whoever needed it and then huffing and puffing your way back to your chair. It's time you got yourself an MFD (Multi-Function Device).

A regular MFD is a sort of all-in-one, with a scanner, copier, and printer in one package. Mid and high-end ones also have a fax. An MFD could have an inkjet or laser printer unit.

A mid-range inkjet printer costs around Rs 8,000, a scanner about Rs 6,500 and a new fax machine will cost about Rs 12,000. You do the math! Instead of spending Rs 26,500 for three units that use more space and resources, you can buy a mid-range MFD for about Rs 18,000.

If you're looking for a colour copier, you should opt for an inkjet-based MFD. High end laser MFDs offer high-quality copies, but are expensive.

An MFD is very often a viable solution, but the amount of work done each day needs to be considered. You can't think of an MFD as a workhorse for one particular type of work. It can never match up to a dedicated device—it's a compromise, but one that could be worth it.

There's a Risk Involved

There's a definite disadvantage associated with an MFD: if one component of the device fails, you'll have to do without all of its functions while it's being repaired.

Another downside is the upgrade option. You can't upgrade just the scanner unit or the printer unit. So you're stuck with it—either sell the MFD and buy a new one, or look for a buy-back deal from the manufacturer.

Here are some instances where buying individual peripherals would be a better option.

The Printer Unit: Though the quality of printing units in MFDs has improved



a lot over time, business users, and professionals in specific fields such as Web designing and publishing, will find that an MFD lacks the quality of a stand-alone device.

Also, most MFDs only support A4 size paper—so for A3 printing, you can't bank on an MFD.

The Scanner Unit: The same applies for the scanner unit. An MFD's scan quality is comparable to a standalone entry-level scanner. However, users who need the quality of a prosumer scanner may get a raw deal.

The Copier Unit: The cost for a copy taken on an inkjet MFD is higher than that of one taken on a regular laser copier. Also, an MFD takes longer for a copy. If your work demands include a large number of copies, it's wise to invest in a regular copier.

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